Gandhi's address in Kanyakumari on 7 September. Accompanying me in the coordination team in Kanyakumari were Sunil Kumar, Dilip Jha and Lalu Kanojia. To ensure a smooth initiation, both Gurdeep Sappal and Pushparaj Deshpande also embarked on the journey along with us from Kanyakumari. In the Tamil Nadu and Kerala legs of the journey, while the nation only witnessed massive public support and crowds, for us it was a logistical nightmare. Even though the Congress party had tried hard to ensure that the Yatra's flavour was non-political, it was impossible to stop local leaders and supporters from enthusiastically joining in. Furthermore, many ordinary Indians joined the Yatra and made it into a huge walking festival. Now most people from civil society who joined were not used to such frenzied crowds and were jostled around. Everyone got separated and naturally felt lost in this huge, snaking Yatra that stretched for miles. So our team's first challenge was to somehow bring everyone together. That meant frantic calls and running around. In those first few days, my team definitely walked much more than the daily 25 kilometres. Every single one of us had severely blistered feet, suffered from dehydration and were physically exhausted.

The other big challenge was arranging for civil society's overnight accommodations. Because civil society originally decided that they wouldn't take any support from the Congress party for accommodation, they decided to arrange for temporary shelter in primary schools, wedding halls and ashrams. People willingly opened their doors for people walking in the Yatra (which they felt was something spiritual and noble). But this arrangement (of not taking anything from the party) put a lot of pressure on our team. After walking 25 to 30 kilometres per day, we had to check the places that civil society leaders had arranged. Sometimes we had to clean those places, provide a helping hand with elderly yatris' luggage, arrange for basic toiletries, etc. At times, we had no choice because we could only arrange mats and blankets for very senior people to sleep on the floor. We frankly felt mortified that we could only do that little, so we decided to talk to the Congress leadership to proactively do something. Thankfully in those early days, we managed with the support of Mathew Kuzhalnadan